

Business Development Program Overview

Business Development is intended to help farmers market their products, gain access to new markets, and expand their current markets. Money can be spent flexibly, but there are some core rules to follow.

Soft spending ceiling	\$15,000
Per-item / bulk limit	No single item or bulk purchase can exceed \$10,000
Equipment Exclusion	A specific item over \$10k, including taxes and any additional fees, is treated as equipment. General items under \$10k must have a specific use connected to a practice. For example purchasing a mower for mechanical weed control in an organic agroforestry system. <i>Shipping can be considered a separate expense.</i>
FSA registered land	BD funds require FSA enrollment. Spending must be tied to a specific FSA registered field
Two Crops	BD funds must be tied to 2 commodities produced on the farm. Both commodities can be Mixed Vegetables for example.
Conservation Practice Requirement	Spending must be tied to an active conservation practice for the two crops and field.

Additional eligibility considerations:

1. **Is this a conservation practice?** If so, the practice should be funded through Conservation Practice Implementation.
2. **Are we disturbing soil?** If so, the project likely requires an environmental review and can't be funded through business development.
3. **Can this expense be tied to a specific field and commodity?** In order for a project to be eligible for funding, we have to demonstrate that the expense is expanding market access for a specific commodity grown in a registered FSA field. Using agritourism as an example: we could likely fund a port-a-potty rental if someone is looking to expand their U-Pick blueberry operation, but not if they want to host weddings.
4. **Utilities, Insurance, credit cards fees and "general operating expenses" cannot be covered**
5. **Double Dipping** - If you are working with another AMP grant or federal program, we cannot fund the same commodity, practice, or field as the other program.

Business Development Ideas List	
Business Development and Planning	Brand Development - Logos, color palettes, and brand guidelines Packaging Design - Product labels, boxes, and retail packaging Professional Photography - Farm and product photos for business purposes Strategy Consulting - contractors for marketing or business plans
Brand Building and Marketing	Digital Presence - Website design & launch, online store and market development General Marketing Materials - Professionally printed brochures, flyers, pamphlets, item list, product labels Signage - Weather resistant signs for fields or market stands
Market & Event Material	Booth Infrastructure - Tables, racks, shelves, chairs, coolers, branded tablecloths Point of Sale Systems - Sales software (Shopify, Square, etc.), Hardware (tablets and card readers)
Food Safety, Certification, and Planning	Certification Fees or maintenance - Organic, GAP, Kosher, etc. Operational Documentation - Professionally built operation manuals, food safety plans, standard operation procedures
Wash/Pack Station and Post-Harvest Handling	Station Infrastructure - stainless steel surfaces, drainage mats, etc. Washing and Drying tools - greens washer and dryers, stock tanks, root washers Handling and Measurements - Bulk containers, totes, weight scales
Cooling, Storage, and Logistics	Climate Control - coolbots, air conditioners, and insulation, chest freezers Environment Monitoring - Sensors and monitors (CO2, hygrometers, thermometers) Storage and Transport - Storage racks, dollies, pallet jacks
Product Protection Supplies	Crop protection - bug/bird netting, tarps, low tunnels, anchors, sandbags,
Other	A purchase outside of the categories above will still be considered. Farmers are encouraged to tailor their budget to their needs.

Payment Schedule	Payment Schedule
\$1500 Stipend	This stipend is paid out upon signing of the General Terms and Conditions contract. It is the one stipend for both Conservation and BD. It is paid out yearly from the date of GT&C signing.
80% of payment	Upon contract signing
20% of payment	Upon Project Completion Verification